PROTEIN CONTENT IN COMMON FOODS*

(*per 100 gram)



Rice	Wheat	Pulses	Milk	Paneer	Bread	Eggs	Chicken
2.5-3 gm	13.2 gm	17-25 gm	3.4 gm	18-20 gm	9 gm	13 gm	27 gm

growing 1.2 times faster than traditional snacks, with one in five snacks now carrying a health association, according to Nielsen's June 2025 Snacking Habits report. "The idea is to incorporate protein into the daily diet in an affordable and tasty manner, in formats that cater to consumers across age groups," says Mehta. "We even offer a high-protein kulfi so you can meet your protein requirement while having a dessert."

Health food brand Yoga Bar, which started in 2014 with protein energy bars, has evolved from a premium brand into a mainstream one, now selling even in Tier 2 and Tier 3 markets. The brand is exploring new formats, including a plant-based protein powder for kids. It will be acquired by ITC by 2026 at a valuation of Rs 500 crore.

Similarly, SuperYou was launched in November 2024 with a single product: protein wafer bar. "We want to redefine snacking by moving from high-carb, high-fat products to offerings that are protein-rich and nutritionally balanced," says co-founder Nikunj Biyani, who started the brand with actor Ranveer Singh. "Our core positioning is that while our chips and wafer bars have fat and carbs, they also have protein," says Biyani.

The legacy category in protein is whey powders, which remain popular. While whey—the liquid byproduct of cheese production—is a good protein source, whey powders have concentrated protein and thus are difficult to digest and can cause bloating. As a result, plant-based proteins are catching up as they are easier on the stomach, says Suhasini Sampath, cofounder of Yoga Bar. Common forms include protein isolates from chickpea, soy, pea, and moong bean. These are processed to remove fibres and minerals, leaving behind a powder that contains 80–90 per cent protein.

Protein products come at a premium because, as Rinka Banerjee, founder of F&B consulting firm Thinking Forks explains, protein isolate costs between Rs 700 and Rs 1,500 a kg. So, if a bar needs to deliver 10 gm of protein, that alone adds at least Rs 5 to the cost. However, Banerjee says their research shows that consumers are willing to pay a 15-20 per cent premium for healthier variants.

A WORD OF CAUTION

When protein is added to commonly consumed foods like milk, yoghurt and paneer, it can be a useful way to increase their protein density, but the concern arises when proteins are added to highly processed 'junk foods' high in fat, sugar and salt (HFSS), like cookies, chocolates, cakes and kulfi. "From a public health standpoint, adding protein to these does not change their unhealthy nutritional profile. Their key concern lies in excess sugars, sodium and saturated fat, and the addition of protein alone cannot negate those risks," says Bharati Kulkarni, director, ICMR–NIN.



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A protein-enriched cookie or cake, for instance, remains an HFSS food, high in calories, and is best consumed in moderation because of the associated risks of non-communicable diseases such as obesity, Type 2 diabetes and cardiovascular disease. Kulkarni suggests that consumers, when considering protein-enriched products, should scrutinise nutrition labels beyond just the protein content.

On the increased popularity of protein powders, Kulkarni says they are not routinely needed, except for specific requirements by, say, elite athletes with high training loads or individuals with protein deficiency. Their overuse, she cautions, can cause digestive discomfort, strain kidneys and displace nutrient-rich whole foods. This is especially true for school children, she says, since their protein needs are modest (20-40 gm/day). A normal diet with cereals, pulses, milk, eggs and flesh food is sufficient. "There is no role for protein powders in otherwise healthy children, and routine use is not recommended."

As consumers seek products high on protein, brands have responded with gusto. But, beyond a single ingredient hype, the market needs to be fortified with more awareness around eating right. It's not just about consuming more protein; it's also about consuming the right type of food in the right way. ■